

People who post about AI environmental impact are completely performative

Posted by u/FamiliarAura • 0 points • 22 comments

I'm not defending AI, but calling out those who seem to make it their personality to hate it. They do not care about the environment, they care about the virtue signaling. AI is bad, yes, but animal agriculture is far far worse. If these people cared about environmental impact, they would change their habits to stop funding deforestation, water usage, pollution, etc. but that takes actual effort. It's super easy to sit on your computer and say AI is bad, that takes 0 effort. 300 chat gpt queries is about 1 gallon of water, 1 hour of TV is about 4 gallons, one chamber is about 660 gallons of water usage. These are probably the same people who shot on vegans, or ignore them. It's pure hypocrisy and it's all performative

Comments

u/streetlightshadow • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:30 UTC

There are many important environmental causes to care about. Caring about one doesn't make you wrong.

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:56 UTC

But it makes you a hypocrite to pretend to care about the environment while choosing to destroy it for flavor and convenience. Making posts judging people for using AI because of the environmental impact, while not acknowledging the harm of your daily choices that are easily replaceable if you care enough is hypocritical and virtue signaling.

u/streetlightshadow • 1 points • 2026-02-07 22:05 UTC

Does it? If I post about all the plastic bags people use to unnecessarily wrap their produce in at the grocery store, am I being a hypocrite because I'm not also posting about AI or fossil fuels? That feels like the same purity test stuff that woke culture deals with and that vegetarians and environmentalists are unfairly criticized for all the time. Not being perfect in every category is hardly a reason to not try in some categories.

But it is a weak excuse to criticize and to rationalize not doing anything.

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 22:10 UTC

If you post about how awful people are for using grocery bags while you have a resin pyramid Etsy shop you are insanely hypocritical. Just like if you post about AI water and land usage while consuming milk and meat you are insanely hypocritical. You should look into the numbers it's sad and scary. AI is still bad I'm not defending it I think everyone is getting confused on that part. I don't use or support AI. And as someone who has made life changes for over a decade to reduce harm to animals and the environment it's very frustrating to see people gloss over that extreme harm and pretend to care about the environment by

posting about AI. Posting is lame no matter what it's about if you're not making changes and doing stuff

u/streetlightshadow • 1 points • 2026-02-07 22:37 UTC

I hear that but right now, I'm in the camp of people doing some good is better than them doing no good and definitely worth more than people knocking them for not doing all good.

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 22:57 UTC

Yet that's not really the point. It's hypocritical to be on a high horse about water and land usage and pretend that you care, while making choices that impact land and water usage 1000+ times harder. That's the point. It's hypocritical. Yes it's good to speak out about anything bad and it never has to be one or the other, just existing is a negative environmental impact. But it is hypocritical to pretend to care about land and water usage when other people do it after ignoring the facts about animal agriculture for years. People like to pretend to be activists when they don't have to actually do anything or make any changes. If anyone cared about water usage they wouldn't even think about touching milk or meat. I hope that makes sense and I'm not trying to argue, but it truly is a hard thing to accept

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-03-16 03:52 UTC

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u/DecembersDragons • 2 points • 2026-02-07 21:30 UTC

It's not performative. It's genuine irritation.

We were on track to solve the atmospheric CO2 problem. Renewable energy sources were gradually displacing burnable energy sources. Consumers were substituting health care and entertainment for manufactured goods. Low carbon services for high carbon goods. Industry after industry was finding ways to operate with less fuel burn.

Then crypto came along and imposed a massive new energy use. For crypto. Don't even get one cheap Chinese made toy rabbit for it. And now AI with another massive new energy requirement. **Completely derails the trajectory we were on.**

There's nothing performative about it. Environmental people are running the numbers and getting pissed off.

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:34 UTC

And yes still AI is not even close to as damaging as animal agriculture is. It is performative to speak about environmental impact and judge others for it while making choices everyday that do far worse damage. Chocies that are not needed. Just people will argue for hours, or years even just to not accept the fact that

animal agriculture is worse. It's cognitive dissonance and not being able to accept the harm we cause along with people not wanting to actually alter their lifestyle to do better. Again, it's easier to just say "AI bad" than to make choices that genuinely help. It's an easy out to virtue signal environmentalism without actually doing anything

u/DecembersDragons • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:40 UTC

Yes. Animal agriculture is worse. But it was already accounted for. Crypto and AI are ****new**** additions to the CO2 balance sheet.

And if you're betting our future on Tony Soprano over there deciding to eat less meat you might as well just sign our death warrant.

I would have killed crypto. Strangled it in it's crib. AI's a bit too otherwise useful to give it that treatment. Vexing.

u/dumbandasking • 1 points • 2026-02-09 21:19 UTC

Yes I was getting upset at first but you know I like your take. I would get rid of crypto. I would want to account for AI development. But I want to go the extra measure. AI is indeed useful, but can we have the progressives start to do development on it too not just bad businesspeople

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 22:24 UTC

I'm not sure I understand what you're trying to say with a few different things, but you can't write off animal agriculture damage because it's already happening. AI is damaging but yes it does have uses, I'm curious where it will take science. But animal agriculture is worse and the only benefit is confidence, taste and not having to actually put effort into making change

u/BoulderSh0ulders • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:28 UTC

So the main issue in this discourse is the misunderstanding of how AI actually effects the environment.

>300 chat gpt queries is about 1 gallon of water

Because this really doesn't appropriately describe the situation.

Firstly, a "query" is a backend thing. When you ask ChatGPT a question it usually generates multiple queries, a more complex request could easily generate hundreds of queries from one question.

Secondly, it ignores the cost of training, which is where most energy and water is consumed by the industry. Companies are constantly training new models.

Thirdly, the construction of data centers themselves consumes massive amounts of resources.

>They do not care about the environment, they care about the virtue signaling

As for motive, I think it's more reasonable to say that young people who hate it are probably moreso coming from a place of frustration about decline in general quality of life. Things are far harder for us than they were for most generations in western modern history, and on top of that we have software which is ruining stuff even more.

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:32 UTC

That is true about misunderstanding AI. People say it's far worse than it is. It is bad, but misinformation makes it sound worse. The true fact and unpopular opinion is that it's hypocritical to sit on a high horse talking bad about AI usage, while actively participating in a non necessary industry that is far far far worse.

u/BoulderShoulders • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:37 UTC

My point is that it is that bad.

>[Because of the energy the world's data centers consume, they account for 2.5 to 3.7 percent of global greenhouse gas emissions, exceeding even those of the aviation industry.]
(<https://news.climate.columbia.edu/2023/06/09/ais-growing-carbon-footprint/#:~:text=Today%20data%20centers%20run%2024,those%20of%20the%20aviation%20industry>)

And then you add this on to the fact that a lot of people have valid concern that this tech will actually be more detrimental to society than beneficial.

u/FamiliarAura • 1 points • 2026-02-07 21:48 UTC

I think I said it's bad at least two times if not more in my post. That's not the argument. It's bad BUT not even a drop in the water compared to animal agriculture, and that is why it is virtue signaling to pretend to be an environmentalist by posting on your computer about AI being bad, while actively choosing to consume animal products multiple times a day, while we know that is hundreds of times worse